Analysing qualitative data usage:
What can (and cannot) be learned from user registration

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UK Data Service

Information about data reuse projects

- Filter for qualitative and mixed methods data
- What we measured – download, not publication or any other output
- Name and email of secondary user
- Affiliation and discipline
- Project name and start date
- Project description (30 word minimum)
- Permission to share information with depositor

Reports sent to all depositors

Hello – this is fantastically helpful, thanks very much. I had no idea that my data was used so much by such a range of people.

BRANDED CONSUMPTION AND SOCIAL IDENTIFICATION: YOUNG PEOPLE AND ALCOHOL STUDY, 2006-2007

Depositor : Griffin, C.;

ESDS Report on Usage of SN 6217, From June 2009 through February 2012

This study has been used in 51 distinct project(s) [Note - table has been redacted to one page.]

First Name	Last Name	Email	Type of User	Discipline	Reuse Project Title	Project Start Date	Reuse Project Description	Permission to make information public?
Abhay	Joshi	abhay_joshi45@hotmail.com	Postgraduate	Business and Management Studies	Dissertation	Apr 6 2010	I want this data for analysis and help in my studies. I am in process to draft my dissertation proposal and so i need this data for further research purpose.	Yes
Angus	Bancroft	angus.bancroft@ed.ac.uk	Staff at institute of higher education	Sociology	Teaching Qualitative Methods	Jan 19 2010	Data to be used for teaching two honours courses, Designing and Doing Social Research and the Sociology of Intoxication, at the University of Edinburgh. Data will be used to explore how qualitative methods construct narratives.	Yes
annie	sayer	amsaye@essex.ac.uk	Postgraduate	Community-based Clinical Subjects	Why don't people use drugs?	Feb 15 2010	If this data is suitable, I will use it for my post-graduate dissertation. I will be doing secondary data analysis on drug usage and the reasons why people might not do these drugs, despite the evidence provided by professor Nutt that cannabis and ecstacy are not as bad for your health as alcohol and tobacco.	Yes
Asija	Safigulina	a.safigulina@rhul.ac.uk	Undergraduate	Economics and Econometrics	Dissertation work	Dec 7 2010	I am working on my dissertation. writing how alcohol consumption affects wages. i need the data to do some econometrical tests to prove my assumptions. that's is why, i need to find the survey wichi wil provide me with the information how much alcohol people consume and how much they earn	Yes
Caoilinn	Hanna	channa26@qub.ac.uk	Undergraduate	Economics and Econometrics	Binary Dependant Variable Project	Dec 3 2010	Need access to data to use as part of a university econometrics projects looking into the statistical signifigance of data. this will not be available publically and only used for the project.	Yes
Daniel	Howdon	ddhh500@york.ac.uk	Postgraduate	Economics and Econometrics	PhD research	Oct 15 2010	ESRC large grant funded PhD research in the Health Econometrics and Data Group at the Centre for Health Economics (University of York) on inequality of opportunity in health and socioeconomic determinants of health.	Yes

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Description of the data

- Time period: 1994 – 2013 (caveats apply in early years)
- Excluded collections
  - 21 with data, but not for download (embargoed, withdrawn)
  - Virtual catalogue records excluded (data held elsewhere)
- 223 qualitative data collections with data available
  - 9 (4%) available, but never downloaded
- 214 collections (96%) downloaded at least once
- 4792 unique downloads of qualitative data

How often are data reused?

Times used	No. coll.	Times used	No. coll.
1-10	102	61-70	4
11-20	49	71-80	3
21-30	24	81-90	1
31-40	7	91-100	4
41-50	8	101-200	5
51-60	6	200+	1
Minimum = 1		Mean = 22	
Maximum = 244		Median = 12	
		Mode = 10	

Who reuses the data?

User type	Number of projects	Percent
Student - postgraduate	1981	41.3
Student - undergraduate	1173	24.5
Student – school and further education	103	2.1
Staff – higher education	1316	27.5
Staff – further education	101	2.1
Staff - other	40	0.9
Government and third sector	61	1.3
Personal, genealogy, commercial	17	0.3
Totals	4792	100

Which disciplines reuse data?

Discipline	No. of projects	Percent
Sociology	1657	34.6
Business and Management Studies	463	9.7
Psychology	437	9.1
Economics and Econometrics	325	6.8
Politics and International Studies	257	5.4
Social Policy and Administration	175	3.7
Geography	171	3.6
Education	149	3.1
Library and Data Centres	147	3.2
History	135	2.8
Law;Ling:Nursing;CompSci;Engl;T&CPlng;Engr	876	18.1
Totals (60 disciplines represented)	4792	100

For what purposes are data reused?

Primary purpose	Number of projects	Percent
Research (includes PhD research)	946	19.7
Teaching and learning (all levels)	3050	63.6
Other uses (test, genealogy, ambiguous)	753	15.7
Unusable (made-up, missing, mismatch)	43	1.0
Total	4792	100

- Coded 30 word description-conservative choices for “Research”
- Used role and title for additional information (e.g., MA on project)
- Coded “Other” if only quant methods described for mixed data
- Limitations of mandating information from users
  - Nonsense – (relatively) easy to exclude
  - Mismatched text more difficult – copy/paste from other reuse projects

Is reuse topic related to original project?

Reuse same or different?	Number of projects	Percent
Different from original (very, e.g., linguistics)	136	2.8
Similar to original	888	18.5
Methods-related (teaching/learning)	1137	23.7
Other (ambiguous, not applicable)	2569	53.6
Unusable (made-up, missing)	62	1.4
Total	4792	100

- Major caveat – in most cases, too little information to assess
- Most teaching reuse is for methods training (this is undercounted)
- Most research reuse is related to original use

Typical reasons given for reusing data

- Instructor did not have own qual data
- Instructor wanted data in specialised methods
  - Constructionist interviews
- A way around ethical review obstacles
  - Student wanted to interview people < 18y.o.
- Methods instruction more effective and enjoyable when data topics match students' interests

Characteristics of most-used data

- Promoted for multiple courses
- Mixed methods, multiple data types
- Topical and policy relevance
- Broad topics
- Small and well-focused
- Student appeal
- 4581-gender; 5049–food retailing; 4841–crime; 4641-employment contracts; 2000-oral history; 5029-cannabis use; 5831-youth justice; 5777-young adults

Teaching and learning – reusers' comments

I just want to read the document to see if it will assist me with my criminology essay for my honours years at college. If that's not too much trouble!!!!!!!!!!!!

I will use the data to teach students principles of interviewing. There are a clear set of interview prompts which are used differently in the actual research interview. I want to show students how they need to adapt a schedule in order to fit the research context.

Having gone to a workshop run by the ESDS earlier this year I am now intending to use this dataset to demonstrate to fellow lecturers the potential of the ESDS for teaching…

I am using this data as part of work for a criminology module …I picked this particular data set because I also study a Policing and the Police module so I thought it would be beneficial from perspective too.

Real interview data is effective in engaging student interest.

Research - reusers' comments

Preliminary stages of designing a mixed methods project to examine social participation in the 1958 british Birth Cohort Study. The aim is to develop appropriate questions for inclusion in the 2008 sweep of the quantitative NCDS survey (with cohort members at age 50) but also to design a qualitative project to explore issues around identity, biography and social participation in more detail.

I am interested in accessing Oral Interviews… to analyse the responses of psychiatric nurses to changes in their profession over the decade following the inclusion of mental health services under the NHS bill. I believe they will give me an unrivalled opportunity to bring the voice of the nurse to the foreground.

This data will be used to pilot test an innovative method for qualitative data analysis using crowd sourcing technology.

How Britain Dies is a research project run by the think tank Demos and funded by Help the Hospices. One focus of our work is to look at the views of dying people and their families around what makes a good death and where people are dissatisfied with how they and their loved ones die.

Questions

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